Above the Stars

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/73646936.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Science Fiction, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Climate Crisis, Climate Anxiety, Bittersweet Ending, Doomed lesbians, Love Confessions, POV Catra (She-Ra), POV Third Person Limited, Depressing

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-11-03 Words: 12,325 Chapters: 7/7

Above the Stars

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/73646936.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Science Fiction, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Climate Crisis, Climate Anxiety, Bittersweet Ending, Doomed lesbians, Love Confessions, POV Catra (She-Ra), POV Third Person Limited, Depressing

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-11-03 Words: 12,325 Chapters: 7/7

Above the Stars

by ChildOfNym

Summary

As the planet is slowly dying, Adora readies herself to leave for a mission she will not return from — and all Catra can do is watch.

Notes

I just felt this would be an interesting scenario to explore so pls don’t think about the logic of it all too hard THANKS.

Chapter 1

Current Day: A letter

The paper card felt heavy in Catra's hands. Its edges were adorned with golden ornaments depicting stellar constellations, and the faint smell of vanilla clung to the ivory paper. One could've mistaken this to be a wedding invitation. But Catra knew better.

Her eyes were caught by the signature at the very end of the text. Even after all this time, seeing that cursive *A* was enough to make a pit open in her stomach.

Catra shoved the invitation back into the envelope. A moment later, it landed in the waste bin next to the post boxes. One shitty farewell had been enough, she didn't need another one, thank you very much.

Back in her flat, Catra didn't bother to flick on the lights. Instead, she tossed her bag aside and stormed right through onto the balcony. The night was murky, her shirt clung to her back. Even up here, the air was heavy with the city's stench. A mixture of dust, gasoline, and a hint of something burned. Sirens wailed in the distance, too faint to be worthy of Catra's attention.

As on the nights before, a soft, orange glow lingered along the eastern horizon. Had she not known its origin to be a burning forest, she might've thought it beautiful.

Catra turned away from the scorched, dying Earth and craned her neck toward the sky. She could not see a single star, and that made it all the worse.

Past: Home I

Adora dropped the last moving box on the creaky coffee table. Her cheeks were flushed red from the brisk autumn air, and a few blonde strands of hair had come loose from her ponytail. She shot her friend a dopey grin.

Catra cleared her throat and quickly glanced away. Adora had a radiance about her that always made Catra's heart beat a little faster—which usually made it hard to stay mad at her friend for long.

Adora stood with her hands on her hips and proudly beamed around the small living room that was now cluttered with dozens of moving boxes. "We really did it, huh?" she said, as if she herself couldn't believe it.

Catra didn't reply. She opened the bathroom door and peered inside. From the mirror above the sink, her dark reflection stared back. So this was really it—after eighteen years of suffering, they finally had their very own place. A new place for a new beginning, with Adora, and without Weaver. Just the two of them. Partners in crime, forever. Or so Catra had thought.

"Catra?" Adora's voice broke through her thoughts. "You aren't still mad at me, are you?"

Catra felt her friend's eyes drill holes into her back. She pulled the bathroom door shut, keeping her eyes glued to the door handle. The TV humming in the background did little to fill the awkward silence between them. "It's just… the whole summer, all you did was talk about the new people you're gonna meet and how exciting it's gonna be."

"Well, yeah. Isn't that the point of uni?"

"I don't know," Catra said. The knuckles of her hand on the door handle turned white. "It kinda sounds like you can't wait to

replace me and have some *actual* fun." Catra forced her eyes shut the moment the words left her mouth. She felt childish, all of a sudden.

Adora came up behind her. She wrapped her arm around Catra's shoulders. "You know that's never gonna happen," she said far gentler than Catra deserved. Catra bit her lip, once again embarrassed of herself and her stupid jealousy. But she just couldn't help it. Adora was all she had.

Adora gave her a playful shake. "You don't need to keep being such a grump, Cat," she continued. "I guess I'm just excited. Think about it! No more Weaver breathing down our necks, no rules, no nothing. We can do whatever we want."

The thought made a smile return to Catra's face. She extricated herself from Adora's hug. "Right, right…" she lamented as she dropped onto the nearby couch. With her shoes still on, she let her feet slide into the cushions. "No Weaver, no rules, no nothing. We can do whatever we want." She pulled out a cigarette from her jacket pocket, ignoring Adora's horrified look. "Like starting with all the things that would've pissed Weaver off."

Adora planted herself in front of the couch and crossed her arms. "I think the no-shoes-inside rule had a reason. And you're not really gonna smoke in here, are you?"

Catra scoffed. "Are you the new dictator around here? I'll keep my shoes on. You're on cleaning duty anyways."

"I don't remember establishing a chores schedule yet."

"I did so just now. You're responsible for the kitchen, bathroom, and the living room"

Adora's jaw went slack for a second. "But that's almost the entire flat! That's not fair."

Catra pulled a lighter from her pocket. "Don't forget my room."

“Stop that!”

Adora jerked the unlit cigarette from Catra’s mouth. Catra reached out to snatch it back, but Adora was faster. She grabbed both of Catra’s wrists and pressed them into the cushions. “What would I get in return for cleaning, huh?”

Catra half-heartedly wiggled under Adora’s tight grasp. She could think of a few ways to thank Adora, but unfortunately, Adora would likely be weirded out by all of them.

“What? Are you making demands all of a sudden?” Catra asked instead. “Isn’t my undying gratitude enough a reward? You ungrateful bastard."

Adora snorted. "Gratitude? From *you*? It’s still a little early for Christmas miracles, don’t you think?”

“Let me go and I’ll show you a proper miracle.”

Adora released her hold on Catra’s arms and leaned back on her heels. But the laughter that usually followed the teasing didn’t come. Instead, the TV had caught her attention.

Catra sighed and twisted her neck to see what was so interesting. The news program was on, and a headline ran across the screen: ‘Earth’s Last Chance: UN Announces New Policies as Climate Catastrophes Surge’. The anchor was talking about rising sea levels and how entire countries were now uninhabitable, while families in flood-prone areas lost their homes to the elements. The usual jam.

Catra cursed in silence. Her hand blindly searched for the remote that had to be *somewhere* between the cushions. She didn’t want Adora to see this. Not now that they were having so much fun.

But it was too late. Adora's smile melted away. She sat back and hugged her knees. “God, it feels like we’re spiraling from one catastrophe to the next, faster and faster.”

Catra nudged Adora with her foot, trying to direct her friend's attention away from the TV. "Hey, I know the world's burning, but at least we get to watch it in 4k."

"But there's got to be something we could do other than just sit here and watch, don't you think? Anything, really."

Catra was well familiar with the despair, the hopelessness, this awful sense of doom that Adora was feeling, but she hadn't allowed herself to really feel these things in a really long time.

"We can't fix this, Adora," she said. "Why stress over it? The world's falling apart, but it's not our fault. We're just two idiots born at the wrong time."

"That's the mindset that got us into this situation. Someone *has* to try."

"Try what, exactly?" Catra asked, now growing annoyed at the fact they were apparently having the same tedious conversation all over again. "Eat less avocado? Thrift toilet paper? Or go to another one of those illegal protests? You still remember how that ended for us last time, don't you?"

Between the cushions, her hand finally closed around that stupid remote. She turned the TV off. Catra wasn't blind to the happenings (far from it, actually) but thinking about these things made her panic. So she chose not to.

"I get how you feel, Adora," she continued. "But I think we were born a little too late for that. Twenty years earlier, maybe, we would've still stood a chance. But today? It's over. There's no turning back, humanity's royally fucked. And you know what? We probably deserve it. I bet Earth can't wait for us to be gone."

"It's funny you say that…" Adora hesitated for a second. She threw Catra a conspicuous glance. "Rumor has it there's going to be a revival of the Alliance program. You know, the space exploration thing they did in the '40s."

Catra raised an eyebrow at her friend. She had a hunch where this was going. “Alliance? You mean the program that accidentally yeeted an entire crew into a star?”

“Yes,” Adora admitted. “*That* Alliance.” She jumped from the couch and started rummaging through the moving boxes.

Catra already knew what her friend was looking for—an obnoxiously thick, tattered notebook filled with hundreds of articles and cutouts about spaceflight. Adora had always been obsessed with that kind of stuff.

“I think it’s in there, together with all the cutlery,” Catra said, pointing her friend towards a box next to the kitchen sink.

A moment later, Adora returned with that personal bible of hers. She flipped through the pages, leaning over so Catra could watch too. “Allience will forever be remembered for that accident, but people keep forgetting that they’ve actually done a lot for interplanetary spaceflight. It was them who brought us to Mars, after all.”

Catra rolled her eyes and leaned back on the couch. She did her best to nod along and throw the pages a polite look now and then, but Catra hardly paid attention.

Would she shut up if I kissed her now? she mused.

"It's when they made the jump to interstellar travel that problems began for Alliance,” Adora continued while Catra was having these thoughts. “The Proxima Centauri mission, was a total disaster, and the entire crew was lost, but guess what? The experimental comm-systems from then are still used today!” Adora’s eyes sparkled with excitement. “Isn’t it amazing? These astronauts and their experiments are the reason interstellar messaging as we know it today is possible!”

“*Fascinating*,” Catra yawned. “So basically, it’s thanks to their sacrifice, we can send nudes across solar systems?”

Adora snorted. She snapped the book shut and gently placed it on the coffee table. Then, she folded her hands in her lap and stared at them, as if she was continuing the conversation in her head.

Catra nudged her friend with her foot. “That’s all very nice, but… there’s a reason you told me all that, am I right?”

“You said that Earth probably can’t wait to get rid of us. And you’re not the first person to think that.”

“So that’s why they’re reviving Alliance? To find a second Earth for real this time?”

“It’s still another ten years or so before the new program is ready to launch, but they’re gonna be looking for recruits pretty soon.”

Catra rolled her eyes. "Oh, here we go.”

"It’s quite serious!" Adora insisted. "Apparently the Brigthmoon family is announcing their involvement any day now, and they have good credibility. You know, I think I could actually pull off becoming an astronaut—"

“Yeah sure, you would make a great space explorer,” Catra snorted. “You’ll find a nice little planet for humanity and name it Catratopia.”

“Shut up,” Adora laughed. She gave Catra a shove, and Catra shoved her back, and within seconds, they were play-fighting on the couch again. Adora had no trouble gaining the upper hand, but only because Catra wasn’t in the mood of putting up a real fight. Being locked in place by Adora like this, with her hips straddled and all, wasn’t exactly unpleasant.

Then the doorbell rang.

Adora hardly seemed to notice. She held Catra tightly in place, the weight of her body pressing down on Catra. “I love when your hair is all messy,” she suddenly whispered. Her words made Catra’s breath hitch.

“I—ugh…”

The doorbell rang again. Adora blinked as she was finally torn out of her thoughts. “I should probably get that,” she said like an idiot.

While Adora got up, Catra stayed on the couch and combed her fingers through her hair. Weaver had always said her hair looked unclean and disgusting, and that she should cut it all off. Catra had kept it long out of spite. Because being spiteful was the only form of rebellion she had.

“Catra?”

Catra looked up, ready to pick up with Adora where they had left off. But it didn’t look like Adora was interested in fooling around anymore. “Why are you wearing your jacket?” Catra asked.

“I just told you,” Adora said. “Seriously, Catra, sometimes you zone out so hard it worries me. What is it you keep thinking about?”

You.

“Nothing,” Catra hissed evasively.

“Whatever. Anyways, there’s two of our new neighbours waiting outside. They said they also study at Ethiria and want to get drinks together. So, are you coming?”

A sudden surge of anger shot up Catra’s throat. “Why should we care about a bunch of losers?” she hissed. “They got no friends or what?”

Adora crossed her arms and tapped a foot—her usual stance when she wasn’t in the mood for Catra’s bullshit. “Catra! *Stop* being like that. We can bail if the two turn out to be weirdos. Come on now.” Adora reached into one of the moving boxes, and after a moment of rummaging, threw Catra her coat. “Please,” she added. “It won’t be fun without you.”

Catra rolled her eyes but put on her coat. It would be fine, as long as Adora was there. *Life* would be fine, as long as she was there.

"Fine, idiot," Catra said. "Where are we going then?"

Chapter 2

Current Day: Reunion

The Runestone Tavern.

Catra stood outside the pub for what felt like an eternity. Ten years had gone by since she'd first come here with Adora and those other idiots, and yet, it seemed little had changed.

Catra tried to calm her nerves by a few taking deep, measured breaths. After all, there was no reason to worry, for this time, *she* was the one in control. A single well-placed, cruel word from her would be enough—enough to make Adora hurt, enough to pay her back.

At least that's what Catra had told herself on the way here. Now, when confronted with the real possibility of seeing Adora again she felt nothing short of terrified.

Catra kept shifting her weight from one foot to another as she tried to coax herself into going inside the pub. The plan for tonight was simple enough. Go inside, make a beeline for Adora, make small-talk, then say goodbye. Also, punch Glimmer on the way out. If a punch was not feasible, a quick slap would probably suffice to get the point across.

Catra's fists curled at the thought of Glimmer. Glimmer and that worm of hers—they were to blame for everything. They had been the ones pushing Adora, cheering her on, feeding this delusional idea that it was *her* who *had* to save the world. Whenever Adora hit a wall, Tech Boy would tweak a screw or filthy-rich Sparkles would make a call, and with that little extra push, Adora would butt her thick head through.

The door to the pub swung open. "Sorry, guys," someone inside said. "Can't let you in. It's a private party tonight."

Catra's ears perked. She knew that voice. Before she could think twice, she brushed past the grumbling group of strangers that left

the pub and slinked inside.

“Sorry, we’re not open tonight, this is a priva—” the bouncer’s jaw went slack for a second.

“Miss me, Water Princess?”

Mermista quickly closed her mouth shut and stepped in Catra’s path, taking all hope of quickly slipping through. “You have some nerve showing up here.”

“Yikes, chill, Guppy,” Catra said. This was pathetic. Of all the people Seahawk could’ve made play bouncer for the night, he’d chosen his own girlfriend. But then again, Mermista was the grumpiest of the lot.

Catra reached inside her pocket and pulled out her very crumbled invitation (which at this point had been thrown into and taken out of the bin at least a hundred times). Mermista studied it from all sides, holding it against the dim light and going as far as sniffing the paper. “Hm,” she finally grumbled. “Seems legit. This is Adora’s handwriting. But you aren’t on the guest’s list.”

“Are you going to let me in or not?”Catra’s hands were suddenly restless, and her throat dry. She needed to get this over with soon, before she lost her wits again.

Finally, Mermista handed Catra the invitation back and stepped aside. “I’m watching you,” she warned.

Catra murmured a nasty response. Then, holding her breath, she dove into the crowd. As her eyes adjusted to the dim light, she felt strangely lost. Things *had* changed after all, it seemed.

The *Runestone* had been completely transformed for the occasion. Banners adorned the walls, depicting stars, astronauts, starships and galaxies. Softly glowing balls were hanging from the ceiling, modeled after the planets of the solar system. Even the table decoration was space-themed. Against her will, the corner of Catra’s mouth curled up. This was probably close to what Adora

had envisioned as a kid when she'd begged Weaver to throw her a space-themed birthday party.

Catra scanned the crowd for familiar faces. There, perched on the counter, she noticed Entrapta, who was nipping on a ridiculously tiny glass of beer. Across from her on the other side of the counter, Sea Hawk was juggling bottles for show. At the very back of the pub Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle—childhood friends she hadn't spoken to in over a decade—were playing a game of pool. She spotted Netossa and Spinnerella, who stood on opposite sides of a beer pong table and were too busy flipping each other off to actually play the game. And then, finally, she saw her.

Adora.

She hadn't changed much in the three years since Catra had last seen her. Still the same dopey, lovely idiot.

To Catra's despair, her former friend wasn't alone. Bow flanked her, along with a few others Catra didn't recognize. New faces. New friends. They were laughing and talking over one another. And Adora was in the very middle of it, drink in hand and smiling so wide it hurt to look at.

Catra suddenly felt ridiculous. She realized that all this time, she had clung to the idea that Adora would be affected by her absence, that she would sit around all night, restless and lost in thought, waiting for Catra to finally, against all odds, turn up. But clearly, that wasn't the case. Adora was doing well without her. No, more than that, she was doing wonderfully—she was *looking* wonderful.

She wondered why she had even bothered coming tonight. Adora's fate was set in stone, and no amount of fighting and pleading and begging would change that—Catra already knew that from experience. And as for goodbyes, she had said hers a long time ago. She turned on her heels to leave, but before she could slip back out the door, someone stepped into her way.

Catra froze. She looked up to see Glimmer standing in front of her, arms crossed and chin high."What the hell are you doing here?" the Brightmoon girl demanded to know.

It was obvious Adora's little terrier was dangerously close to making a scene. And that was too good of a temptation to resist.

Catra forced a smirk. "Nice to see you too, Sparkles."

"You are not welcome here," Glimmer said, as if she was reciting a law of nature. "This is Adora's night, and she doesn't need you ruining it. How did you even know about the party? Have you been stalking her?"

Catra just pulled the invitation from her pocket, not caring to answer. Glimmer's eyes almost popped out of her skull. "Who gave you that?"

"Who do you think?"

For a moment, Glimmer looked genuinely taken aback. "No way. Adora would've told us."

Catra couldn't help but feel delighted at the obvious insecurity that flashed in Glimmer's eyes. "Well, she didn't," she grinned.

Glimmer crumbled the invitation and threw it to Catra's feet. "You don't get to just waltz back into her life like this. You won't get another chance at destroying her dream because you're too selfish to let go."

The words hit harder than Catra expected. It wasn't the hate in Glimmer's tone that hurt, but the truth behind her words — the fact that Catra was, indeed, too selfish to let go.

Suddenly, it was Weaver's voice again that echoed in the back of her head, calling her the old, familiar things, exposing who Catra deep down really was.

Pathetic, useless, spiteful.

Before she could stop herself, Catra's anger boiled over. "You think you get to decide that?" she snapped. "You don't own her, so stop playing gatekeeper!"

Glimmer slammed her drink on the next best table. The thud was loud enough to turn nearby heads. "I'm protecting her from people like you!"

"Oh, so now I'm the bad guy for being the only one here who's not completely brainwashed with this stupid Alliance shit?"

"Stupid?" Glimmer starred at her in disbelief. "We all worked our butts off to get where we are today, and you've got the nerve to call the Alliance mission *stupid*? You … you know what, let me ask you something. How have *you* been doing, Catra? Huh? What did *you* achieve in your life? I mean, apart from being Adora's biggest hater? Oh, that's right—nothing."

Catra's fists clenched. Oh, how she wanted to punch this girl's teeth out. "Last time I checked I was not about to throw my life away to chase the pipe-dream of some eccentric billionaire! It's a suicide mission you're sending her on!"

"It's a chance for all of us!"

"No, it's suicide," Catra insisted. She raised her finger and rammed it into Glimmer's shoulder. "And if something happens to her up there, if something goes wrong, *you* and only *you*, are the one to blame. You and your precious Bow. You two pushed her into this, made her think she had to save the damn world! You made her think she didn't need—"

"Didn't need what? You?" Glimmer interrupted. She slapped Catra's hand away, her eyes cold as ice. "Because she doesn't. She doesn't need a toxic, pathetic asshole like you in her life."

Catra opened her mouth, but before the words could escape, a large, familiar figure stepped between them.

"Whoa, okay, let's all just calm down! Hey, Glimmer, I've got this. Why don't you go back to the party?"

"I'm not going anywhere, *she* is going to ruin Adora's farewell—"

Scorpia placed a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "I said I got this," she repeated firmer this time. "We don't want Adora's farewell party to end in a bar fight, do we?"

Glimmer glared at Catra for a moment before she huffed and stomped off.

Catra exhaled. She let herself be steered toward a quieter corner by Scorpia.

"What the hell are you doing here, Scorpia?" she asked after they'd sat down. She'd suspected that Scorpia had loosely kept in touch with some of Adora's friends after Uni, but Catra was still surprised to see the girl here, out of all places.

"Oh, I'm Perfuma's plus one tonight," Scorpia explained, shrugging. "She's over there somewhere, talking about plants or chakras or something. I was unsure if I should come, I've never been that close with Adora, but to be honest, I had a hunch you might show up tonight. Figured someone should keep an eye on you."

Catra's eyes narrowed. "I don't need a babysitter."

"Well, maybe not, but it looks like you need a friend," Scorpia replied, looking quite satisfied with herself. "Wanna talk about what just happened?"

Catra hesitated. She glanced toward the bar, where Glimmer was shaking her head and muttering to Bow.

"Actually, no. I shouldn't have come here."

"Why not?" Scorpia asked. "It's the farewell party of your best friend. It's probably the last chance you'll ever get to see her

alive. I mean, the chances of success are already quite low to begin with, but even if they manage to reach LHS, it's meant to be a one way trip so …"

Catra felt her face crumble as unwelcome tears shot into her eyes. Adora was such an idiot. Such a fucking idiot. "You're not helping, Scorpia," she hissed, quickly wiping her cheeks with her palm.

"Oh right, god, I am so sorry," Scorpia said. Guilt was written all over her face as if she'd just broken an entire cabinet of priceless china. "It's not exactly a pleasant thing to think about. But I admire her. Somebody's got to go on this mission, or else, our children won't have a place to live anymore. And hey, who doesn't want to go to space?" For a moment, Scorpia looked like she wanted to drape her strong arm around Catra's shoulders, but in the end, she knew better than that. " Just go talk to her," she said instead. "I'm sure it'll be fine."

"It *won't* be fine."

"Why not?"

"Because she's clearly doing fine without me! She doesn't need me, and she doesn't miss me."

In the end, Scorpia couldn't resist. She placed a hand on Catra's shoulder."Hey, maybe you and Adora grew to be very different people, but that doesn't mean she doesn't appreciate all the memories you made together. You matter to her, Catra. And maybe, it'll make leaving easier for her, knowing that you… *approve*."

Catra shook off Scropia's hand. She'd always hated being touched by anyone other than Adora. "I'm not gonna pretend I'm suddenly fine with it just to make her feel better about throwing everything we had away."

"I see," Scopria sighed, finally giving up. "I mean… it's your choice in the end, I'm not gonna force you. But hey, will you at least have a drink with me? We haven't talked in ages."

Catra cocked her head. “You know what? Why not. But none of that pisswater beer!”

They went up to the bar where they met Entrapta, who started to drown Catra in tech talk like no time had passed at all. Moments later, she felt a tap on her shoulder. It was Double Trouble, an old acquaintance who’d moved back to the Crimson Waste ages ago to pursue their acting career. And suddenly, the four of them were together again, the old crew who used to party at the Frigthzone from dusk till dawn. Catra ordered a round of drinks for her old friends. Maybe coming here hadn’t been the worst idea after all.

She was just starting to relax when she caught something suspiciously pink in the corner of her eye. At the very other end of the counter stood Glimmer, gesturing wildly. Even through the buzz of the crowd, Catra could understand her shrill complaints quite clearly.

“I can’t believe you invited her and didn’t even tell us!” the Brightmoon girl spat at Adora. Bow stood next to his friends, head helplessly tucked between his shoulders.

Catra leaned against the counter and twirled the ice in her drink. She was so ready for the drama to unfold. “Oh, this is gonna be good,” Catra whispered to Scorpia. “Just watch.”

“It’s not a big deal,” Adora said. “I didn’t think she’d actually show up, okay?”

“You didn’t think? Yeah, I noticed that much.”

Adora threw Bow a desperate look. “I was just... I don’t know, I was hoping maybe things could be... better.”

Glimmer stomped like a moody teenager. “*Better*? Are you kidding me?”

“Guys,” Bow interjected, holding up his hands. He gestured towards the half-open backdoor behind the bar. “Can we not do this here? Everyone’s going to hear.”

“Let them hear!” Glimmer yelled, throwing her arms up. “I’m not the one who throw a grenade in the middle of her farewell party!”

“A grenade?” Catra said loudly enough for the others to hear. She pushed herself off the counter and stepped closer. All three heads snapped in her direction. “I’m flattered, Sparkles. Really.”

Adora’s eyes shot wide open, and Catra’s racing heart almost leaped out her throat the moment their eyes locked. She knew that if she looked at Adora for even a second too long, she would fall apart here and there, so Catra quickly forced her attention back to Glimmer. If the Brightmoon girl wanted a scene, she’d get one.

“I didn’t realize you cared so much about me, Sparkles, and I must say I’m *moved*. But don’t worry, I wasn’t planning on playing homewrecker for long.”

Glimmer looked like she was ready to burst, her face had taken the colour of a beetroot

“What’s wrong?” Catra snarked. “Afraid I might actually have a conversation with Adora without you supervising?”

“That’s enough!”

Adora stepped between them, and suddenly, Glimmer and the whole crowd were in the background, unimportant and forgotten. “I invited you because I wanted to see you. I wanted to talk to you and try to make things right.”

“Adora, why are you even talking to her?” Glimmer interrupted. “All she ever did was drag you down and hate on you.”

Catra already had a sharp reply on her tongue, but Adora was faster. “You don’t get to decide that, Glimmer,” she simply said.

That finally silenced Glimmer. She turned on her heels and stormed off, with Bow following after her.

Adora threw Catra a questioning look, then nodded towards the back door.

Catra's smirk turned into something crooked and painful. Part of her wanted to walk through that door, step into the calm of the night, right into Adora's arms. But another part of her was raging, eager to take the opportunity that was suddenly presenting itself—the opportunity to get back at Adora, to hurt her just as bad as she'd hurt Catra.

For a moment, the two voices inside her head fought for dominance, this mix of fear, hate, love, cowardice.

Her reluctance to follow didn't go unnoticed. Adora's eyes widened and betrayed something like panic as seconds tickled on. The simple hint of emotion was enough to make Catra rejoice.

Yes, she thought. *Show me how much you still care.*

She would not follow, Catra decided then—she could not. Not again, not after what had happened out there between them all these years ago—this single, fleeting glimpse of what could've been.

"No thanks, Adora," Catra forced herself to say. "I think I'll pass. Sparkles is right. You don't need me."

She turned on her heels and hurried outside.

The cold night slapped her across the face as the tavern door swung shut behind her, cutting off Adora's voice calling her name.

Chapter 3

Past: Home II

Catra groaned as sunlight sliced through the cheap blinds. Pain throbbed behind her eyes, and she made a mental note to invest in blackout curtains. She dragged a pillow over her face and groaned. "If the sun could explode already, that would be really fucking great."

Next to her on the couch, Adora sat up, clutching her head. "What the hell did we drink last night?" she rasped.

Catra peeked out from under the pillow. "Acid."

Adora chuckled. She let herself flop back onto the couch and hugged Catra from behind, burying her face in Catra's hair like she'd done countless times before.

But suddenly, her whole body stiffened. "I'm sorry, is this okay?"

"Why wouldn't—" Catra's voice trailed off as the memories of last night slowly returned. Blurred faces, laughter, smeared vision, the warmth of the pub and Adora's arms. The backdoor of the Runestone, the silent alley, the cold brick against her back. Adora's hands cupping Catra's face, her friend's hot breath on her lips, kissing her, their bodies pressed together.

Catra's face flushed, and her stomach tightened in a weird way. "I… ah…"

Adora pulled back at once, her head now a ridiculous shade of pink. "Sorry, I didn't mean to make it awkward." She swung her legs over the side of the couch and stood. "We have food somewhere around here, right?"

Catra watched as Adora wobbled toward the fridge like a reanimated corpse. Her heart was racing. *Now is the moment,* she thought. She could say something—anything—and it would be all out in the open. "No, it's alright," she croaked instead. "We were just drunk, right?"

"Yeah, right," Adora said with a nervous laugh. For a moment, she shuffled around the kitchen like a headless chicken, before finally regaining her wits. "We'll feel better after eating."

And just like that, the moment was gone, and the awkwardness dispersed. They'd just been drunk. Of course. Catra exhaled the breath she'd been holding. "So, what exactly makes you think food prepared by *you* is gonna make this any better?"

Adora opened the fridge and peered inside. "Will I ever hear the end of it? I gave you food poisoning *one* time…" she complained as she pulled out a carton of eggs. Then, she grabbed a frying pan from the counter and turned on the stove.

Catra watched Adora crack the eggs with varying degrees of success. "Hey, pro-tip, the eggs are supposed to go *inside* the pan, idiot."

"Wow, I didn't even know," Adora said drily. With her hands, she cupped the unfortunate egg yolk that had landed on the counter and threw it into the frying pan.

Meanwhile, Catra stretched on the couch to claim the newly gained space and stared to the ceiling. Now that the memories of last night had come back, they were hard to ignore. If Adora hadn't mentioned it, Catra would've just assumed them to be some sort of hallucination. But Adora had actually kissed her … or had she kissed Adora? She bit her lip. Whatever happened last night, it didn't help her quest of getting rid of her feelings for Adora the least. She wondered if Adora would do it again, if they were drunk enough.

After some minutes, Adora plated the eggs. She handed one plate to Catra and shoved her legs aside to have some space to sit on the couch.

"Thanks," Catra murmured, poking at the eggs with her fork. "I guess."

"Try not to act too grateful."

Catra hesitated for a second, the awkward moment from before still painfully present in her mind, but then she leaned against Adora, watching her best friend from the side as they ate.

"So," Catra started, "what's Sparkles' excuse this time?"

Adora blinked in confusion. "Huh?"

"Glimmer," Catra clarified. "She was even more wasted than you. What does she blame it on this time? Peer pressure? Too much money in her bank account?"

Adora grinned. "Actually, she blames Bow for letting her do shots. Says he's a terrible influence."

"Right, because Bow's such a bad boy."

Adora laughed. Her voice was still raspy from last night. "You should've come with us after the Runestone. It was fun."

"No thanks," Catra said. With a clatter, she tossed the plate with her half-eaten breakfast onto the coffee table. "I'll take Scorpia's nonsense over Bow and Glimmer any day. At least she knows how to party without giving me a lecture."

Catra laid back down as she spoke, resting her head in Adora's lap. Her fingers danced along the seam of Adora's pyjama shirt, playing with loose threads. Sometimes, when she felt brave enough, she let her knuckles brush against Adora's naked stomach. But not today. Not after what happened between them last night.

"They're not that bad," Adora said, peeking down on Catra over the rim of her plate. "You'd like them if you gave them a chance."

"Doubt it," Catra muttered. She tried blowing a strand of hair out of her face, without much success. Adora brushed it out of the way for her and tucked it behind Catra's ear. "Why does it bother you so much when I spend time with them?"

“It doesn’t.”

“Yes, it does,” Adora insisted. “You’ve been weird about them ever since we met them.”

Catra turned on her side, facing away from Adora towards the TV. It always felt weird looking directly at each other when talking about things that bothered her. “Maybe because ever since you started hanging out with them, you’ve been acting all different,” she murmured. The words spilled out before she could stop them.

“Different?” As she spoke, Adora traced the ridge of Catra’s ear with her finger. Catra closed her eyes, enjoying the sensation. Ever since Weaver was out of their lives, Adora had grown so incredibly soft with her. It was far from what Catra actually wanted but … still, on most days, it was close enough.

“Well, you’re always talking about these big dreams now,” Catra whispered. “Like that stupid space program.”

Adora withdrew her hand at once. “It’s not stupid!”

“It’s ridiculous,” Catra shot back. She sat up to face Adora. “You really want to chase some billionaire’s pipe dream?”

Adora’s jaw tightened visibly. “Catra, it’s something I’ve wanted for a long time. You know that.”

“You wanted to be an astronaut,” Catra reminded her. “For space walks and the moon and stuff. Not for some crackhead mission that will kill you!”

“It won’t kill me—”

“What if something goes wrong?” Catra interrupted. Despite her best efforts to sound angry, she had a hard time hiding the fear in her voice. “What happens if something breaks along the way, or you have some freak accident and you don’t come back? What if it’s a one way trip?”

Adora's expression softened at once. "Catra," she said, "If I really manage to get into the program, I'll probably be gone for a year or two but … of course I'm coming back! You know that, right? I won't go onto some kind of suicide mission. I'm not that stupid."

"Oh, really? Because you can be pretty, pretty stupid at times."

"Not when it comes to this. Besides, you're the reckless one of us. Have you forgotten that?"

Catra exhaled, defeated. Adora was right, of course. She'd always been the more grown up of them two—the one who would fix things, the one to rely on. She lowered her head back into Adora's lap."Fine," she said. "But you have to promise."

Adora's hand found her way back to its old place, now gently combing through Catra's hair. "Promise what?" she asked quietly.

"Promise you won't leave me behind."

"Of course I won't," Adora said. "You know I couldn't."

"Good." Catra closed her eyes again, focusing on Adora's hand. "Because if you leave, I'll have to chase you down and drag your dumbass back."

Adora chuckled. "I'd like to see you try."

Chapter 4

Current Day: The Call

The world outside Catra's apartment window looked dead. For half an hour now, she'd tried reading the same cursed page of her book, but her brain refused to focus. Her eyes always drifted away, lost in thought, waiting for … something. The end, maybe.

A headline flickered across the muted TV. "Alliance Mission Prepares for Final Countdown – Two Weeks Until Launch."

There was a photo of Adora beside the headline, standing in her pink flight suit. It was a special kind of cruelty, the fact that even now Catra couldn't escape that face, for the whole world's eyes were on the Alliance mission. The same blonde hair poof, the same stupid grin—and something else. Something that, despite her best efforts, Catra couldn't ignore. Adora was carrying the weight of the world, and it began to show.

She tossed the book aside and sank further into the couch. The blue lights of an ambulance or firetruck weakly flickered through the curtains, accompanied by distorted siren wails.

Catra's phone buzzed. She only threw it a glance. Unknown number. Probably a scam. She stared into the dull darkness of her flat. Then she picked up.

"Hello?"

For a moment, there was just static. Then a voice she hadn't expected to ever hear again spoke.

"Catra."

Catra sat up straight. "What the hell. Sparkles?"

"Don't call me that," Glimmer said, but there was no real bite to her voice. If anything, she sounded tired.

Catra's legs were suddenly restless. She jumped to her feet and began pacing her flat. "How the hell did you get my number?"

"Does it really matter?"

"I suppose not," Catra muttered. "What do you want, you creep?"

Glimmer remained silent for a moment. "Are you at home?"

"… No."

"Your lights are on."

"What the—"

"Meet me downstairs."

Beeping. Glimmer had ended the call. Catra threw a panicked look to her window, as if she was expecting Glimmer to stare right back at her—which was nonsense, of course, since she lived in the third storey.

For a moment, Catra stood like a lost ghost in the middle of her flat, torn right through the middle. In the end, she quietly cursed and threw on her jacket. Her curiosity had won.

Glimmer was leaning on a wall down the street with her hood up. She was busy trying to look tough, but the screeching pink colour of her hoodie didn't help.

Catra lit a cigarette as she approached. "Hey, Sparkles," she greeted. "Remember the other day, when you accused me of stalking?"

Glimmer pushed herself from the wall and threw her a look. "It wasn't exactly hard getting your address. There's a reason Scorpia never got past basic security clearance at Alliance."

Catra exhaled smoke. Of course. Scorpia must've been *thrilled* to help Glimmer out with this. But if Glimmer needed to talk to her, why not just ask Adora for her contact? Unless Adora wasn't supposed to know she was here tonight.

Glimmer shuffled on her feet and threw an uneasy glance around. "Say, is there any place we can go and talk? The air's awful tonight."

Catra pinched the bridge of her nose. Where the *hell* was this going? What was so important to Glimmer that it couldn't possibly be talked over on the telephone? "There's this fast food place two blocks away. Serves super greasy fries and stuff. Great if you wanna clog your arteries."

"Good enough."

Catra's thoughts raced as they walked in silence. Something was in the bushes here … something suspiciously Adora-shaped. She took a last puff from her cigarette and flicked it away. Then she entered the fast-food place, Glimmer in tow.

They were the only patrons. A neon OPEN sign threw blue reflections on the greasy floor tiles. Somewhere in the kitchen, the cook dropped a basket of fries in. The place stunk of old oil and sweat.

Catra ordered the next best thing from the menu and chose a booth by the window, where they sat facing each other.

Finally, Glimmer pulled her hood back. Under the harsh overhead lights, she looked like a ghost. Her skin was pale, and there were dark circles under her eyes. It seemed Adora wasn't the only one feeling the weight of it all.

Catra crossed her arms and leaned back in her seat, throwing the girl in front of her a measured look. "So?"

"How to say this?" Glimmer began. "See, it's about Adora."

Catra scoffed. She'd already guessed that much. "It always is about Adora, isn't it?"

"She isn't doing too well."

"She seemed fine to me at the Runestone."

"Yes," Glimmer admitted. "But not anymore. She's trying to keep everyone calm and pretend things are fine, but they're clearly not. She's not sleeping, she barely eats. Bow's worried sick. Her performance keeps dropping, the crew is getting nervous. We can't send her up like that."

"Then don't," Catra said without hesitation. Her heartbeat had picked up. Was Glimmer here to tell her that Adora had been deemed unfit for flight after all? That she could come and take her home at last? It was almost too good to be true.

Surely enough, Glimmer shook her head. "She's captain now, we can't just pull her from the crew without pushing the mission back. Plus she'll insist on going anyway. She is not going to change her mind. You should know that best."

Catra slumped back into her seat. "Then what do you expect me to do about it?"

"What she needs is real closure, and I think you're the only one who can give it to her. I know it's a lot to ask for from someone like you."

Before Catra could answer, their food arrived. The fries looked limp and way too oily. They both forced tired smiles as they thanked the waiter.

After he'd left them alone, Catra pressed her hand against her forehead as a ache started building right behind her eyes. She could really do with another fucking cigarette. "So let me get this straight," she groaned. "You really think a phone call from me is gonna fix whatever is going on in that thick, stupid head of hers?"

"Maybe not. But it could be a start."

They both fell silent. Outside, thunder rolled somewhere beyond the hills, and first droplets of acid rain thumped against the window.

"You're still not convinced," Glimmer observed.

Catra shook her head. "No. I don't see why I should help you with this."

"Okay, listen," the other girl said, leaning in. "There's something you should know then. To be honest, I'd hoped I didn't need to tell you, because I think you're an insufferable asshole and don't really deserve to know, but here it goes. Adora loves you. Like, in that special way—whether she admits it or not, and I'm tired of pretending I haven't noticed. I'm tired of her trying to ignore it, and I'm tired of her insisting it doesn't matter what she wants or feels."

Catra froze. No, it couldn't possibly be—Glimmer was simply making things up to manipulate her. But the words still tore right through her.

She loves you.

For a moment, Catra imagined Adora saying it, with that dopey grin plastered across her face. It was ridiculous, simply impossible.

Why would Adora love a worm like you? Weaver's voice mocked.

"You're wrong," Catra said bitterly.

"I'm not," Glimmer insisted. "If you don't believe me, go around Alliance and ask anybody with a pair of eyes in their head. It's so painfully obvious. Everybody knows. Everybody but Adora herself."

Catra stared at the fleck of ketchup on her plate. Her pulse was hammering in her ears, it felt like a floodgate had been opened

inside her. In all those years of loving Adora she'd never even considered the idea that Adora might feel the same for her. But if Adora truly loved her in that way, she would've never left. So of course, Glimmer was wrong. But on the small chance that she wasn't …

Glimmer seemed well aware of her inner turmoil, for all of a sudden, she pointedly ignored Catra. They finished their food in silence. When they finally stepped outside, the air had turned sour from the acid rain.

"I can give you her private link," Glimmer suddenly said, as she pulled out her mask. "It's a direct line to her unit at Brightmoon Space Center. She's not exactly supposed to get outside calls at this point, but Bow can make it happen. He's pretty good at getting around the official stuff."

"I'll think about it," Catra answered hesitantly.

Glimmer let out a breath of relief. "Please do. Once she's off-planet, there's no turning back. So don't wait too long, okay? "

"I know," Catra murmured. She pulled her hood up to protect her face from the rain. "I won't."

Chapter 5

Past: Winter

The Christmas music in the air annoyed Catra like a mosquito buzzing too close to her ear. But it was part of the package called 'Holiday Spirit', and there was nothing to be done about that. The soft glow of the lights wrapped around the trees bounced off the shiny surface of the artificial ice rink. The lack of snow to cover the muddy surroundings was a bummer, but people had learned to stop hoping for white Christmas—or snow in general.

Catra adjusted the laces on her skates and glanced toward Adora, who was clinging to the railing of the rink like her life depended on it. Catra couldn't help but smirk. Adora was good at sports that required strength and speed, but when it came to balance, she was a lost cause.

Adora shot her a look. "This is definitely the last time I let you pick a surprise activity!"

Catra stepped onto the ice with effortless grace. She made a point to skate backward as she passed Adora. "You know, for someone who supposedly hates global warming, you're pretty afraid of ice."

Finally, Adora pushed herself off the railing. Frozen in a ridiculously wide stance, she slowly glided into Catra's general direction.

Catra skated up beside her and held out her arm. "Let me steady you. I'm not in the mood for medical emergencies today."

"I've got this," Adora insisted, but she held onto Catra's arm anyway.

They moved together across the ice. Despite Adora's initial complaints, Catra knew she'd made the right call tonight by bringing her friend here. The best way of getting Adora's mind off all her worries was to give her a good old challenge. And it worked like a charm. For the first time in weeks—no, months,

actually—there was no hint of the tension that had been growing between them.

It took a few rounds, but eventually, Adora grew confident enough to let go of her arm. She shot Catra a triumphant grin, and it was pretty enough that Catra decided to be nice and pretend Adora didn't still move like someone had strapped skates to a stork.

After a while, they stepped off the rink to warm up with mulled wine from a nearby stand. They held their cups close as they huddled together on a bench next to the rink.

"This wasn't a bad idea," Adora admitted, blowing on her drink. "Almost worth the hours of studying I had to sacrifice."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Adora, it's impossible to score more than a hundred percent on a test. So stop studying like you're trying anyway."

"You know damn well I can't stomach bad grades," Adora reminded her. "But I'm glad you dragged me out here. I didn't know you were into … festive activities?"

Catra shrugged. "Well, maybe I'm trying something new. For us."

Adora scooted closer until their legs touched. "Thanks," she said. "I mean it. I know I haven't been easy lately."

Catra looked away quickly, pretending to take a sip. "Oh, you never are…" Her cheeks suddenly felt hot, and it wasn't just the wine. Her free hand wandered into the pocket of Adora's coat. A moment later, Adora's hand joined hers inside.

They sat in silence for a while, watching the other skaters glide across the ice and enjoying the warmth of their intertwined hands.

"Look at how fast these kids are," Adora said, pointing her cup at a pair of girls racing each other across the rink. "They're what, four years old? And already so good at this."

Catra's stomach twisted in a weird way as she watched the kids. She wondered (not for the first time) what it would be like to have a small version of Adora running around the flat. It was another forbidden thought, locked away so deep inside her even she herself cringed at the idea of entertaining it. On the other hand, not too long ago, she would've considered confessing to Adora a forbidden thought too, yet here she was.

"Did you ever think about kids?" Catra heard herself ask. She immediately regretted having brought it up. *Enough of this goddamn wine,* she thought.

Lucky for her, Adora had only half listened. "What?"

"Oh, nothing," Catra said hastily. "It's just … these girls remind me of us. That's all."

Adora squeezed her hand in her pocket and threw her a soft smile. "Hard to believe we used to be that cute once, right?"

"You still are."

The words spilled out of Catra's mouth before she could stop them. Instead of answering, Adora buried her face deep in her scarf, but Catra could swear her friend was grinning.

Encouraged by that, she took a final, deep breath. This was it. The perfect moment to finally tell Adora how she felt.

"Hey," she began. "There's something I—"

"Me too," Adora interrupted. Her eyes suddenly beamed with excitement. She set her cup down and turned to face her fully. "There's something I've been wanting to tell you."

Catra's heart was pounding in her ears. "Okay," she said slowly. "You first."

Adora withdrew her hands and folded them in her lap, where she nervously twisted her fingers. "I got in, Catra. The Alliance

program. They accepted me. Glimmer and Bow have been right all along."

Catra stared at her friend. "You... got in?"

Adora nodded. A dopey grin spread across her face. "Yeah. I leave in a few weeks for training. That's why I need to get all my coursework done."

Catra's throat tightened. She'd dreaded this moment for years, and now it was suddenly real. She struggled to fend off the awful, all too familiar spiral of panic.*It's gonna be alright,* she reminded herself. *Adora has promised everything will be alright.*

"That's amazing. I'm proud of you," she forced herself to say. The weird thing about these words was that somehow, she meant them—she *was* proud of Adora. She'd always known her best friend had something about her, something that made her different. Maybe that's the reason Catra had always been so scared of Alliance. She'd known that Adora would make it, if she set her mind to it.

Adora's face lit up like a Christmas tree. "You have no idea how much that means to me. I'm not gonna lie, I was so scared of your reaction."

"Why?" Catra asked as the pit in her stomach continued to grow into a gaping hole.

"Because you always—ah, never mind. It doesn't matter. What matters is that I can actually make a difference!"

"Yeah," Catra said mechanically. "I still don't see why saving the world should be your lone responsibility but you got what you always wanted. I guess Glimmer and Bow are happy all their hard work paid off? I mean, I'm not saying they got you in or anything."

"Oh, they definitely helped," Adora laughed. "I wish I got in on my own, but it is what it is." She reached over and squeezed Catra's

hand, and that's when Catra noticed her friend's hands were shaking. Why were they shaking?

"That's not all of it, is it?"

Adora shook her head. "Not quite," she said. She threw a glance around before lowering her voice. "I've signed a NDA so technically I'm not supposed to talk to you about it. See, they identified a candidate planet for our program. LHS 1140 b it's called."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Wow, catchy. Sounds like a great name for a planet if you want to scare off tourists."

"It's not supposed to be a vacation spot, Catra. It's a potential new home for humanity."

"Yeah, but if I'm packing my bags and leaving Earth behind, I'd hope we'd be moving to something called, I don't know, Paradise Prime or Eden 2.0. Not a planet that sounds like a barcode."

"Well, we're not ready to move there for another generation or two anyway. We need to build a lot of infrastructure first, so I think Alliance's marketing has time to come up with something more to your liking in the meantime." Adora shook her head, a sad smile on her lips. "God, I'm gonna miss you and that stupid mouth of yours."

Catra froze. "What do you mean? I thought you're just supposed to scout the planet for a year or two."

"Uhm." Adora let go of Catra's hand and started fidgeting "Here's the thing..."

Catra stared her friend into the ground. The laughter and holiday music echoing from the ice rink were suddenly too shrill, she had to resist the urge to cover her ears. A cold, feverish sweat broke out on her forehead.

“Adora,” she croaked. She gripped her cup tightly to give her shaking hands something to hold onto. “What do you mean you’re going to miss me? Just how far is that planet away?”

Adora whispered something to her shoes.

“What did you say? Spit it out Adora!”

“I said I’m not coming back.”

Catra’s cup slipped out of her hands and shattered on the ground. She must’ve misheard. There was just no way. After all, Adora had promised—

“We’ll need to spend fifteen years in cryosleep just to get there,” Adora continued. Her voice was jumping across octaves, she barely got the words out.

“So I’m not even gonna be able to hear a single beep from you for fifteen years?” Catra stood abruptly, for she could no longer endure the proximity of their bodies. “How long?” she asked. “How long have you known it would be like this?”

Adora’s face betrayed her. She’d known for way longer than she wanted to admit, apparently. “Please, Catra, don’t be mad at me,” she pleaded instead. “I was going to tell you, I swear! I just didn’t know how to bring it up, okay?”

Catra had to laugh at the absurdity of it. “*You didn’t know how to bring it up*? You’re supposed to be smart, right? A smart, brave genius who’s gonna colonize another world for humanity and yet you ‘don’t know’ how you’ll bring up the fact that you’re gonna abandon your best friend? God, you’re fucking unbelievable.”

Catra dimly noticed nearby people staring at them. She must’ve yelled that last part, she realized.

Adora jumped to her feet too, raising her voice. “You think I want to leave everything behind? You think I don’t wish there was another way?”

“Then don’t go?” Catra shouted. “Stay here! Stay with me! Stop acting like it’s so fucking hard!”

Something shifted in Adora’s face then. Her jaw tightened, and emotions Catra had never seen before flashed across her friend’s face.

Disappointment.

“I can’t, Catra,” she said, her voice strangely cold. “You know I can’t. This is bigger than us. It’s the only chance I have to make a real difference.”

“Always the hero, huh? Always playing the savior.” Catra had meant her words to cut, but they came out thin and weak as tears suddenly filled her eyes. “You’ve got to fix the world, no matter what it costs. Even if it means throwing away everyone who cares about you.”

Adora helplessly lowered her hands. “I didn’t mean for this to happen. You know I care about you—”

“Not enough,” Catra hissed. “Not enough to stay. Not enough to even give me a choice. You decided all of this without me. You didn’t even ask me what I wanted. Not *once*.”

Adora’s shoulders slumped. Her next words were barely a whisper. “So tell me, what *do* you want, Catra?”

Catra blinked, thrown off for a second.

You. Always you. Forever you.

“For you to fuck off!”

Finally, that one hit. Adora’s face crumbled. “Catra, I don’t think I can do this without—”

Catra didn’t let her finish. She’d heard enough. “Oh, you can. You chose this. So live with it. Go. Be a hero. Save the world. Just

don’t expect me to be waiting for you when you wake up.”

“Catra...”

“Goodbye, Adora,” Catra said. Then she stormed away, leaving Adora standing alone beneath the twinkling lights and fading music.

Chapter 6

Current Day: Another Goodbye

Catra checked her watch and hummed quietly to herself as she drummed her fingers on the hood of her car. Entrapta had told her once that the old burner-engine cars people used to drive back in the day still got hot, and that cats and such would often sneak under the hood during winter to be close to the leftover warmth. Now, Catra wished for such a car. She hadn't known the desert, out of all places, could get this cold at night. She could've waited in her motel room, but she didn't want to miss even a single second of tonight.

On the nearby highway, trucks thundered past, their headlights slicing through the chill night only to be swallowed by the dark a moment later.

Catra checked her watch again and sighed. Hardly thirty seconds had passed. She'd never been the patient kind. What made it worse was that she didn't actually know what kind of car she was waiting for. Or maybe it would be a bike? Or one of those little golf-carts they surely used to get around the huge Brigthmoon complex?

Catra snickered at the thought. She was in a strange mood.

A hundred or so watch-glances later, a car finally pulled off the highway into the motel parking lot. It rolled slowly through the rows of parked cars, as if looking for something. Catra pushed herself off the hood and stepped out of the shadows.

The car stopped abruptly, then reversed into the nearest free spot. It took all of Catra's self control to not just sprint up to it. Instead, she approached with slow, measured steps.

The headlights switched off, and a moment later, Adora emerged from the driver's seat, a backpack slung over her shoulders. Her face was hidden in the dark, but Catra recognized that hair poof easily enough.

They met halfway. For a moment, the silence was thick and awkward between them.

Catra cleared her throat. “Nice place you picked”

“Yeah,” Adora said, fumbling with the zipper of her hoodie. “I used to stay here the weeks before my unit at Brightmoon was ready. You know, after you threw me out the flat and all …”

Catra scratched her head as if a flea had bitten her. “Yeah, sorry about that, by the way. I kinda lost it there.”

“Well...” Adora nodded past the motel, toward the desert. “So, I thought we could take a walk? There’s a path leading up a small hill. Great for stargazing and bonfires and stuff. It’s not far.”

Catra gestured. “Lead the way.”

They walked side by side in silence, careful not to get too close. Catra’s whole body was tense to the point of snapping, hyperaware of every inch of air between them.

Adora led them past the motel and around the corner with the waste bins. Humid air rose from a half-opened kitchen window, and an old air conditioning unit wheezed and rattled.

“Sooo,” Catra began. “I thought you were under lock and key?”

“I’m not a prisoner,” Adora clarified. “But yeah, you’re technically right. They do take quarantine pretty seriously seventy-two hours before launch.”

“So you could get into big trouble for being out here?” Catra asked as they struggled through a hedge of dry, dead bushes. Whatever path might’ve been here once, it was long gone.

Adora pushed a batch of branches out of the way for her. “Me being out here endangers the whole mission, if you must know.”

Catra brushed past her. “Did I mentioned I had a stomach bug just this morning?”

“Oh, shut up,” Adora scoffed, letting the branches snap back into place. “You’d really like that, huh? If I everything is blown off last minute because I decided to sneak out and meet you.”

Catra watched from behind as Adora pressed on into the desert. “Sorry,” she murmured, “I was just trying to make a joke.”

Adora slowed, allowing her catch up. “I’m sorry too, for snapping at you. I’m glad you drove all the way out here. What is it, five hours?”

“Almost six,” Catra corrected. “It’s nothing, really.”

Adora hadn’t lied, the spot wasn’t far. Still, it was far enough from the motel and the highway that all traces of artificial light disappeared.

Catra’s eyes were drawn to the sky, and she couldn’t help but gape. For a moment, her jaw went slack, and she was at loss for words. “I … I didn’t realize there was so many of them.”

Billions upon billions of stars sprinkled the sky. This was nothing like the city, where you might see one or two bright dots, if you were lucky.

Adora came up beside her. Their arms brushed. “Isn’t it beautiful?”

Catra looked at her friend, and suddenly, she got it. She really did. Not the suicide-mission-part, but this other obsession, this childlike wonder Adora had always felt when it came to the universe. “And you get to see that every night out here?” she asked.

“Well, no,” Adora sighed. “I haven’t actually been able to look up in a long time. The Space Center’s perimeter is always completely lit. It’s hard to see any stars at all.” Her hand rested on Catra’s

arm, then slowly slid down until it slipped into her hand. “That’s why I was so excited to meet you out here,” Adora admitted “I wanted to see it one last time. The sky’s gonna be a lot different where I’m going.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Oh, yeah. Sure. Don’t mind me then. Should I give you and the cosmos some privacy?”

“You’re such an idiot,” Adora laughed. The tension in Catra’s chest eased at the sound. She’d made Adora laugh. Progress.

Adora let go of Catra’s hand and set down her backpack. She pulled out a blanket and spread it on the ground.

Catra raised an eyebrow. “Oh? Date night?”

Adora suddenly fumbled with her hoodie zipper as if it was a lifeline. “*No...* Well, maybe? I don’t know? Ah… hm… ” Crossing her arms, she sat down onto the blanket and pressed her mouth shut to prevent any more nonsense from spilling out.

Catra couldn’t help but chuckle. If she’d only known earlier how Adora felt (and how much fun it was to tease her!), maybe things would’ve been a lot different. She lowered herself next to her friend.

“I’ve been meaning to ask you,” Adora said, “how are you doing?”

Catra blinked, thrown off by the absurdity of the question. “*I*?”

“Yes, you. I realized all we ever talk about is me and my mission. Part of why I invited you that evening to the Runestone was to find out how you’ve been doing… so I know that you’ll be okay, that you’re not in trouble.”

Catra’s eyes narrowed. “And what if I was?”

“Was what?”

“In trouble. Say, prison for drug smuggling or something.”

“Well, I would’ve told Glimmer and Bow to take care of it.”

Catra flopped onto her back and stared up at the stars. “No offense,” she said, “but sending those two clowns after me would definitely feel like a last, grand ‘fuck you.’”

Adora wisely ignored the jab at her friends. “You’re not really in trouble though, are you?”

“Eh.” Catra said, gesturing vaguely. “I did run a semi-illegal gambling website for a while with some idiot called Hordak. They fined me for that, but I managed to hide away a decent bit of the money. Gotta put that unfinished maths degree to use *somehow,* right?”

“You know what?” Adora said, lowering herself next to Catra. “I already regret asking. Consider my curiosity satisfied.”

“Right, back to talking about our messiah Adora.”

“I’d rather not,” Adora murmured. “I’d rather just be Adora tonight.”

They both fell quiet after that. The rocky ground beneath them still held some of the day’s warmth, Catra could feel it through the thin blanket. The stars above crawled across the sky as time passed. Now and then, shooting stars zipped through the dark.

“You know,” Catra said after a long while. “I never really asked.”

“Asked what?”

“Where is it? The place you’re going. I need to know where to look when I think about you.” She’d croaked these last words. “For the rare times I’ve got nothing better to do.”

Adora studied her. Maybe she was weighing the sincerity of her words. Then, she scooted close until their heads were next to each other.

She raised her hand, guiding Catra's gaze across the sky. "The star our planet orbits is too faint, you won't see it with the naked eye, but I can show you were it would be. Here, you know Pisces, right? It's one of the zodiac constellations, you'll find it easily enough with some practice. If you'll go down from there, you'll cross Cetus. My planet's close to the beta star, that's the second brightest of the constellation."

Catra followed Adora's hand as if in trance, trying to burn the pattern into her mind. "So if I look there, I'll see you?"

"Yes," Adora answered. "And I know where Earth is. So I can look back. We can wave at each other."

"It's not the same," Catra said quietly. She was close enough now to see the stars reflected in Adora's eyes.

"No," Adora agreed. Her hand found its way to Catra's cheek, cupping it gently. "It's not the same."

Catra's breath hitched. "Adora?"

"Hm?"

"There's something you should know."

Adora leaned in, her eyes half-closed and lips parted. "So?"

"I'm not saying it to make you stay. But I need you to know before you go." Catra took a last shaky breath, as if she was to plunge into a bottomless ocean. Then, finally, after years and years, she allowed the words to spill out. "I love you."

Silence. Agonizing, endless long seconds of silence in which Adora's thumb kept moving gently against her cheeks. Finally, she laughed quietly. Closing her eyes, she leaned in until their foreheads touched. "You had to say it now, didn't you?"

"I'm mean, I know," Catra said with burning cheeks.

Adora exhaled as if the weight of the world had been lifted from her shoulders. “I love you too,” she whispered. And just like that, she leaned in to kiss her.

In that moment, Catra’s world reduced to the sensation of of Adora’s lips on hers, and she could’ve cried. It was all she ever wanted, and soon, it would be gone.

When they broke apart, Catra burried her face in Adora’s shoulder, her eyes burning. “You better look back at me from that stupid planet of yours.”

“I will,” Adora murmured. “I promise, I will.”

Chapter 7

Epilogue

The observation deck felt cold and sterile. Screens covered every inch of wall space, displaying every possible angle of the launch side and never ending stream of plain text telemetry data. The air smelled faintly of chlorine, old coffee and cold cigarette smoke.

A giant window spanned the far wall of the observation deck. Beyond, the rocky desert stretched pale and endless in the faint light of dawn. And in the distance, the rocket stood tall like a tower from a forgotten age.

Catra paced the small lounge at the edge of the deck. She'd been here since well before sunrise, earlier than most of the staff. Sleeping hadn't really been an option the last couple of days.

All morning, the control room had buzzed like a hive of bees at work, but it wasn't until the buzz died down into a tense quiet that Catra's heart began to race.

As the hour of launch came closer, people lowered their voices as if in a church. Technicians whispered updates, a woman at the comms station read through final checks with a cold, steady voice. Glimmer and Bow were sitting close by. They'd greeted Catra earlier this morning with thin-pressed mouths and tight jaws, but had ignored her from then.

From the Control area, a woman's voice crackled through the speakers. "T-minus two minutes. Crew, commence final systems check."

"Copy that. Begin final system check."

It was Adora's voice that answered, slightly distorted and static. Catra gripped the cold metal railing so tightly her knuckles turned white and closed her eyes . It might be the last time she'd hear

Adora’s voice for at least 15 years… or maybe, forever. She shook her head, trying to banish the thought.

“All systems nominal. Ready for launch.”

Behind her, Glimmer made a choked sound, and Bow reached for her hand.

“T-minus one minute.”

The last conversations in the room died. Catra’s heart hammered so hard it hurt. She tried to imagine Adora sitting in that cramped cockpit, suited up, eyes glued to some telemetry screen, the stars waiting above for her.

“Ten... nine... eight…”

“Go,” Catra heard herself whisper. “Go and save us all, dummy.”

“Three... two... one... ignition.”

Silence. The ignition couldn’t be heard from here. Flames flared at the base of the rocket. And slowly, like a titan rising from the depths of Earth, the rocked left the ground. It was slow, so agonizingly slow at first, then going faster, leaving a column of smoke behind.

“Liftoff confirmed.”
Applause broke out across the room. Catra hardly noticed. She just pressed her forehead to the cold glass.

The comms crackled again.“Brightmoon, this is Captain Adora. Everything’s great up here.”

“Copy that, Captain. Safe travels.”

The rocket shrunk to a tiny, white speck, then vanished into the clouds. Catra dug her hands into her pockets and turned on her heels, leaving the observation deck.

She stepped outside, slipping past the hundreds of reports and onlookers that had gathered around the perimeter. For them, she was just another face in the crowd.

She threw a last look towards the desert, were the launch site lay in the distance. By now, the sun had finally climbed above the mountains and a new day had come. The horizon glowed golden.

And somewhere beyond the clouds, Adora was on her way.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!